

“Take any open source project – its contributors cut across national, religious and racial lines”

Noufal Ibrahim is the co-founder and CTO of **Genskill** (an ed-tech startup focused on solving the skill gap problem in engineering). He also founded PyCon India in 2009 and is a member of the Python Software Foundation. He is active on GitHub and Stack Overflow.

In an exclusive interaction with **Sreejani Bhattacharyya** of *OSFY*, Ibrahim talks about his journey, career, and how he thinks the FOSS ecosystem has shaped up.



Noufal Ibrahim was introduced to programming when he was around ten years old and considers it his calling. He says, “When I was in college around 2000, I discovered the Internet and the availability of software that you could build yourself. I was drawn to the idea of seeing the actual code of programs that I would use on a daily basis rather than just pre-built binaries. Around this time, I also started hearing about the Free Software Foundation and the UNIX operating system (especially the Linux flavour). I became a bit of a zealot thinking that I was doing something noble by defending open source and free software from proprietary giants like Microsoft.”

Fascinated by the writings of Richard Stallman and Eric Raymond

He recalls that the arguments on how Linux is superior to Windows were common over late-night tea at the college canteens in the nerd circles. The writings of early free software and open source pioneers like Richard Stallman, Eric Raymond, etc, fascinated him, and he had the desire to be “one of them.” Ibrahim searched for ways in which he could contribute and started small.

He adds that most of the stuff he has worked on has been in Python, though not exclusively. He has contributed what is known as drive-by patches to several projects. He has also contributed to SQLAlchemy, which is a popular Python library, and

has worked at the Internet Archive where he co-wrote an archiving http proxy and related libraries, which allow archive crawlers to make copies of large websites easily. He has also written a few personal projects for his own satisfaction like a front-end for a popular static blogging system, a library to get system information in a cross-platform way, etc.

Ibrahim says, “Open source is not all technical, and there is a strong community angle to this. During my college days, I’ve been involved in small ways with local user groups, where I used to conduct classes and tutorials on various topics. Once I moved to Bengaluru to work, I got heavily involved in the Python community and organised the first Python conference

